Milan

Dear Sam,

Forgive the ink spots on this page. I write quickly when an idea is chasing me, and this morning one chased me all the way across Milan. I am Leonardo, from the little town of Vinci, and I am told you are an inventor. Then we are already friends.

When I was young, I learned my trade in the workshop of Master Verrocchio in Florence. We painted, carved and built machines, all under one roof. I learned there that artists and engineers must both do the same thing first: look very, very carefully.

These days I am filling my notebooks with birds. I watch how they tilt their wings to turn, and how they ride the wind without flapping. I have drawn many designs for a machine that might let a person fly. None of them flies yet. But each drawing teaches me something the last one did not.

If you ever see my notebooks, you will notice something strange: I write backwards, from right to left. I am left-handed, and it suits me. To read it, you need a mirror. I have written one line for you at the bottom of this page so you can try.

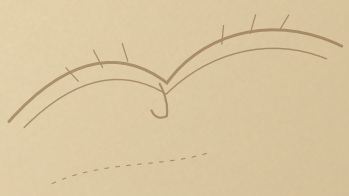
They also tell me you play a game where you kick a ball. I would very much like to draw how your leg moves when you kick it. Everything that moves has a secret, Sam. The fun is finding it.

Your fellow inventor,

Leonardo

P.S. What is the best invention you have ever dreamed up? Draw it for me if you can.

Hold this line up to a mirror. This is how I write in my notebooks!



REAL HISTORY

The true story behind Leonardo's letter, for Sam and a grown-up to read together.

1. Leonardo da Vinci was born in 1452 near Vinci, close to Florence, Italy. He was a painter, engineer and inventor.
2. As a teenager he trained in the workshop of the artist Andrea del Verrocchio in Florence.
3. He was left-handed and often wrote in mirror writing, from right to left. Thousands of pages of his notebooks survive today.
4. He studied how birds fly and drew designs for flying machines, but none were built as working machines in his time.
5. Storytelling: the ink spots and the idea chasing him across Milan are imagined, and Leonardo never wrote to anyone in the future.

Write back to Leonardo!

Write here or on any paper you like. Then ask a grown-up to take a photo of it and upload it in your Letters from History account. Leonardo's next letter will answer you.